

We recognise the important role First Nations people play in our workplace. We aim to attract, recruit and develop First Nations staff.

Our priority is to ensure a safe workplace where we celebrate all cultures.

Work for us

Find out how to [apply for a job](#).

We encourage First Nations people with relevant skills and experience to apply.

Working here is such a great experience and a great learning curve, and knowing that you're protecting what our ancestors passed on from their lifestyle, their culture, pass on their knowledge down to generations and generations. The Department of Agriculture and the people of Torres Strait sort of have that same drive to care for country and to protect their sea states and rights. The APS in general really shapes and moulds that professional aspect within you. If you take the time to be patient and persistent in pursuing a career in Australian Government, the opportunities will arise. My ancestors protected this country before I did in different ways, and now I feel as though I'm doing the same thing with this role. You know, I'm protecting it from pests and diseases. So that's, for me, how it aligns with my values, personally and culturally. From the First Nations perspective, what you're doing is you're actually looking after country when you're doing what you do every day in terms of all your responsibilities, and the position is quite, yeah, it's quite good.

Entry level programs

We participate in APS-wide entry-level programs for First Nations recruitment and development.

Entry-level roles

We participate in entry-level job programs for First Nations people.

Indigenous Apprenticeship Program

The [Indigenous Apprenticeship Program \(IAP\)](#) runs for 12 months. On completion you'll have:

- a permanent full-time job at the APS 3 level
- tailored support to help you thrive
- a Certificate IV or Diploma in Government.

The IAP is run by Services Australia.

Indigenous Graduate Pathway

The [Indigenous Graduate Pathway \(IGP\)](#) is part of our graduate program. It supports your transition from university to the workplace.

In this pathway, you'll be supported by a First Nations mentor, liaison officer and staff network.

The graduate program runs for 12 months. It includes:

- a structured learning and development program
- full-time work experience
- on-the-job training
- access to graduate-specific events and opportunities
- positions across Australian capital cities.

See more

Find out about our [Graduate Development Program](#), which recruits from the [Australian Government Graduate Program streams](#).

Our strategies

We aim to improve the representation of First Nations people.

We're guided by:

- The [Reconciliation Action Plan \(2021-24\)](#)
- The [Commonwealth Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Workforce Strategy 2020-2024](#)
- Our [First Nations Commitment](#)

Hear from us

Dakota

Dakota Killer

My name's Dakota Killer. I am a Section Officer in Compliance Partnerships. During my first year in the traineeship, I was lucky enough to experience multiple different areas within the department. So I got to see enforcements, document assessment, the client contact group, inspections, so quite a variety. My ancestors protected this country before I did in different ways, and now I feel as though I'm doing the same thing with this role. I'm protecting it from pests and diseases, whether that's through the actual physical inspections of pests and diseases or whether that's looking at the policy related to it, or supporting the people that do that work. So, that's for me, how it aligns with my values personally and culturally. I think that anyone should think about joining the department, someone who's passionate and driven. The department has a lot of opportunities for different types of people, if you're looking at being a data analyst, if you want to be a scientist, if you want to work with animals, if you want to work in a fast-paced environment or a slow-paced environment, the variety and the options are just unlimited. So honestly, I think that as long as you have the connection to the department, its values, and that passion and the drive, then you should definitely think about joining.

Gayai

Gayai Uiduldam

So my name's Gayai Uiduldam. I'm originally from the Torres Straits. I'm a Biosecurity Engagement Officer with the Indigenous Rangers Business Management Section with the Department of Agriculture. The department is well established within the Torres Straits, having the risk of exotic pests and diseases coming from Asia in that PNG area through the Torres Straits. So, applying for the job, I was well aware of the position and the responsibilities. The Department of Agriculture and the people of Torres Straits sort of have that same drive to care for country and to protect their sea states and rights. One day, you could be in the office doing emails or reviewing observations that the rangers send in. The next day, you could be out on country engaging with Indigenous rangers, traditional owners and relevant stakeholders. So, I identify as both Torres Strait and Aboriginal. The department has a range of diverse and inclusion groups. It makes it easier for people such as myself to fit in and find a safe space to be a part of. The department, really, were flexible to help me adjust to the work life and giving me a good balance of work life and professional commitments. I've been very lucky in my opportunities. I've actually been in the Australian Public Sector since I left secondary school. I really do think my background and my journey so far in the APS is a good example for young First Nation Australians, and especially school leavers and uni students. The APS in general really shapes and moulds that professional aspect within you. If you take the time to be patient and persistent in pursuing a career in Australian Government, the opportunities will arise.

Phil

Philip Anderson

My name's Philip Anderson. I'm a Biosecurity Officer for the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry. Working for the department is not exactly what you think of as a government job. I'm not office-bound, I still get out and do inspections. It's a border agency and you're a border officer, so you're actually a first point of contact for exotic pests that are coming into the country, looking after a variety of different imports into the country. Once I started with the department, after I've come in under the Indigenous Apprenticeship Program, there was three clear pathways. So I started at the airport for a period of time, then I was to go to cargo, and then vessels, I did a little bit of vessels. And so you get a broad overview of exactly what the department did at the time, which was quite good. After you've done a little period of all your accreditations, you can settle into some of the more complex inspections. And those complex inspections can give you the opportunity to inspect offshore, which is mainly linked to the military program. So you get the opportunity to get some international travel. People who should think about joining the department are people who have a belief in looking after the best interests of the country. We look after the health of the economy, we look after human health, and we look after agricultural health. From the First Nations' perspective, what you're doing is, you're actually looking after country when you're doing what you do every day in terms of all your responsibilities in the position is, yeah, it's quite good. So I'm always trying to get people into the department or into these opportunities that they have with their cadetships, et cetera. To come into the department, you have to

do a little bit of work. When you're in the department, you have to do a little bit of work, but the rewards are good for you and it's good for your family and it's good for your community.

Valent

Valent Kirk

My name is Valent Kirk. I'm a Biosecurity Officer for the Department of Agriculture I'm a Torres Strait Islander. I've been in the department for nine years and I'm currently based here in Cairns. My job is to inspect incoming vessels, cargo, and aircrafts coming in from the Torres Strait, making sure they're clear from any biosecurity risk materials such as plant, soil, and animal. Throughout our day, we'd head down to our local cargo area and we're inspecting common cargo such as vehicles, trucks, going through the truck, making sure they got no biosecurity risk materials, making sure they're clean, making sure they got no soil or grass materials, plants. When we do come upon those, we collect them, sample those, and then pass it on to our scientist to inspect. I did travel a lot from Cairns, worked back up in the Torres Straits. I also travel up to PNG, conducting biosecurity awareness to the coastal villages up on Papua New Guinea, making them aware what we look for when they arrive into the Torres Strait, the importance of biosecurity. What do I like by working in DAFF is protecting my island home. We grew up growing and eating local fruit and veg up in the Strait, so working here is such a great experience and a great learning curve, and knowing that you're protecting what our ancestors passed on from their lifestyle, their culture, passed on their knowledge down to generations and generations. Moving from Thursday Island down to Cairns and working here in the Cairns office is good, and working with other cultural diversity, learning their culture and learning their life experiences as well, so a great learning experience for myself. Passing on my knowledge of what I've been taught up in the Straits is a great thing to do as a Torres Strait Islander myself. It makes me feel proud knowing that I'm doing my part in protecting home is such a rewarding feeling.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/jobs/first-nations-people>